

pre-installed with commercial software from vendors such as Microsoft, Oracle, and IBM, with a higher hourly charge.

Add-ons to this service are also available for a more customised experience:

- **Elastic Block Store:** For adding storage volumes to your EC2 instance. These cost on a per-GB basis, and on how many data operations are performed. These can also be set to be backed up to Amazon S3 at the standard costs.

- **Elastic IP Address:** Assigns a static IP address to your instance, if you need to to host your web site.

- **CloudWatch and Auto Scaling:** This service monitors your This service can be set up to automatically launch additional instances of your server whenever demand increases, and shut them down if demand goes down, thus saving on costs.

- **Elastic Load Balancing:** Automatically distributed requests across your running instances to balance the load.

These services aren't for an amateur! The Amazon S3 service for example, will give you no means by itself to access your files. All you get when you sign up are your access credentials, which are long complicated alphanumeric sequences contrived beyond remembrance. They do provide loads of developer documentation for creating software to access the service, and sample code to help you get started. You are by no means helpless, as people have been kind enough to create code for you to integrate these services, often seamlessly into your work-flow.

Rackspace

Another strong contender in this area is Rackspace's Mosso services. They provide three Cloud services – Cloud Sites, Cloud Storage and Cloud Servers.

Cloud Sites:

With cloud sites, your entire server is hosted by a pool of virtualized servers. The minimum package gives you 50 GB storage space, 500 GB bandwidth, and 10,000 compute cycles a month (equivalent to a 2.8 GHz processor).

This minimum package costs a whopping \$100! However, they offer no restrictions on how many sites you host on the platform, or how many databases and email accounts you create, so you can even 'sub-let' the unused capacity to run your clients web sites. Excess usage charges are in the order of \$0.50/GB for storage, \$0.25/GB for bandwidth and \$0.01 for each additional compute cycle.

Unlike Amazon EC2, this is a ready-to-use product, and requires no further set-up or costs to enable load-distribution or automatic scaling. As such it is much more suitable for hosting purposes.

Cloud files:

This is an alternative to Amazon S3. The facilities are quite similar, with similar pricing structures and design.

Unlike Amazon S3, Mosso provides an online interface for accessing your content, and infact does not charge for bandwidth used from their own control panel.

It's raining clouds

A list of cloud services

Google Docs
ZoHo Suite
box.net
HD Cloud
Sun Grid
Microsoft Azure

Cloud servers:

This is more on terms with the Amazon EC2 service, but stands out enough to be a force of its own.

Cloud servers gives a much more fine-grained control over the server configuration, with a minimum configuration server with storage of 10GB and 256MB memory available for as little as \$0.015! On the other hand the minimum configuration available in EC2 costs 10 times as much.

A penny saved?

The best thing about these services (except Cloud Sites) is that there is no minimum fee at all! For zero use there is zero payment. Even landlines cost more. So you can sign up today, and you won't be charged a single paise till you upload that first byte, or launch that first server instance.

Cloud storage services cannot replace the storage provided by a web hosting provider. These storage services are better optimized for media files and downloadables. By running your core system through a web-hosting provider, and integrating media from these services, you stand to save much more.

Unlimited hosting accounts may seem attractive, but the level of service and availability provided by cloud services is substantially better. Unlimited bandwidth is unfeasible, and usually one of the service provider's other constraints kick in at exactly the wrong time. There is no such thing as a free lunch, and the recipient of one is sure to be skeptical of where exactly the lunch has been that it's free in the first place.

Since cloud services are pay-as-you-go, you get the same level of service and

speed whether you are hosting a multi-terabyte media web site, or a 1GB backup. The broadband and storage are truly unlimited, because you are paying for them.

If you can't afford \$100 a month for your next venture, Cloud Sites will be off the table. The alternatives EC2 and Cloud Servers are, raw products, which need intense cooking with a development team in order to be feasible. If you need a simple solution with minimal development involved, these services too will seem unnecessarily contrived.

A penny earned

The true advantage of cloud hosting appears only for those who have demand cycles that vary considerably. In cases where the minimal package required will be insufficient during higher loads and will attract large fines, and the maximal package will cost considerable more. With a normal hosting provider, singular aspects of the hosting package cannot be scaled individually. If you need lower storage space, but considerably higher bandwidth, you are out of luck. Here offloading some of your heavier files to the cloud stands to be much more efficient.

Finally to take full advantage of the emerging clouds, it is best to consider all aspects of your hosting configuration. Run benchmarks, how much do you use at your peak? Does the hosting provide sufficient speed for downloads? How much do you have to pay for exceeded bandwidth?

As always it is best to take a middle path if unsure. You have a hammer, don't make everything into a nail. In all likelihood there are much cheaper places to host your awesome blog. For simple purposes, it is quite an overkill. Whether the cloud works out for you or not in the end depends on your required mixture of performance and cost. **4**

MOSSO / AMAZON S3 RATE COMPARE

Operation	Mosso Cost	Cost
Storage	\$0.15	\$0.15
Data Transfer IN	\$0.08	\$0.10
Data Transfer OUT	\$0.22	\$0.17
Requests: PUT, COPY, POST, or LIST (per 1,000)	\$0.00	\$0.01
Requests: GET, etc. (per 10,000)	\$0.00	\$0.01